

A STAR IS BORN

19-year-old **Kimi Antonelli** leads a Mercedes 1-2 while Hamilton grabs breakthrough Ferrari podium.



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The podium ceremony at the end of the Chinese Grand Prix in Shanghai was laced with a touch of nostalgia. The Italian and German national anthems played together, bringing back memories of former world champions Michael Schumacher and Sebastian Vettel popping the champagne on the top step. But this time around, it wasn't a German driver winning with an Italian constructor.

For the first time since 2006, when Giancarlo Fisichella triumphed in the Malaysian Grand Prix for Renault, the chequered flag at the end of the race waved for an Italian driver.

Mercedes' Kimi Antonelli (**below**) earned his first F1 race victory at just 19 years of age, becoming the second-youngest F1 race winner after Max Verstappen. The Bolognese driver displayed maturity well beyond his years, in just his second season in the top tier of motorsport, to pip his teammate George Russell in a second consecutive 1-2 finish for the German manufacturer.

It was an almost flawless drive from young Antonelli, who had become the youngest pole-sitter during qualifying ahead of the race. A lock-up at the hairpin a few laps from the end had everyone clutching their seats. The Italian himself said it "almost gave him a heart attack", but he recovered to comfortably take home the full monty.

Antonelli's win was also a moment of redemption for team boss Toto Wolff, who had copped a fair bit of criticism for replacing the departing seven-time world champion Lewis Hamilton (**facing page**) with an error-prone rookie. "He's too young. We shouldn't put him in a Mercedes. Put him in a smaller team. He needs the experience. Look at the mistakes he makes.' Here we go, Kimi. Victory," the Mercedes team principal said in his post-race radio rant.

Young blood: It was an almost flawless drive from Antonelli, who became the second Italian driver since 2006 to win a Grand Prix.

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